

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Man not guilty in Bovino murder-for-hire

Jury acquits construction worker, delivering swift repudiation of Trump administration

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A federal jury on Thursday found a Chicago construction worker not guilty of charges he solicited the murder of Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino, delivering a swift repudiation in a case the Trump administration had held up as evidence of violence toward immigration officials.

After a lightning-fast trial, the jury of six men and six women deliberated for about three hours before acquitting Juan Espinoza Martínez of the one count of murder for hire that he faced.

Before the jury was brought in to read the verdict, Espinoza Martínez stood in U.S. District Judge Joan Lefkow’s courtroom as his attorneys helped him put on a lavender tie and adjust his collar.

In the courtroom gallery, his younger brother, Oscar Espinoza, sat hunched forward and clutching a small silver medal of St. Jude, the patron saint of lost causes who, according to his testimony at the trial, became a symbol of hope for the family during their father’s recent illness.

When the verdict was read, Espinoza Martínez, 37, kept his hands clasped in his lap as he looked up in apparent relief and a slight smile crossed his face. About 20 feet away, his brother made the sign of the cross and pumped his

fist.

The quick not guilty verdict marked a stinging rebuke in what was the first criminal case stemming from Operation Midway Blitz to go to trial — one that seemed to get weaker for the prosecution at almost every step of the proceedings.

To date, nearly three dozen people have been criminally charged in U.S. District Court on immigration-related cases since the deportation surge began here in early September, mostly involving protesters or observers accused

of assaulting agents.

Some 14 cases were dropped or dismissed before ever getting to trial, a staggering record for a Justice Department with a conviction rate typically above 90%.

The verdict also comes weeks after a Tribune investigation found that the vast majority of protesters arrested during Operation Midway Blitz were never charged by prosecutors with any crime, despite federal agents sometimes sensational claims of violence.

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Mina Rajaei, a graduate student at Northern Illinois University, on Wednesday. Rajaei has had two calls with her mother in Iran lasting two minutes each since the internet blackout there. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Iranians in Chicago struggle to communicate with loved ones

Families face uncertainty after deadly, anti-government protests convulse Iran

By Laura Turbay
Chicago Tribune

The first question Mina Rajaei asks her family when she is able to reach them back home in Iran is: “How many of us are killed?”

It’s the grim reality for Rajaei, a computer science student at Northern Illinois University, and others in Chicago’s Iranian community who are facing uncertainty about their loved ones after deadly, anti-government protests erupted in late December.

Since then, it’s been nearly impossible to contact those in Iran after a communications

blackout, Iranians in Chicago say. People in the U.S. are unable to call into Iran, though people there may call out, they said. Even so, the calls are usually brief and vague out of fear the government is monitoring them.

“We actually don’t know what’s happening to our family,” said Rajaei, 30, of Iran, who attended a rally last Saturday in Chicago against the Iranian government’s crackdown. “Whether my brother is alive or not.”

Since then she has spoken to her mother for a brief two minutes and knows her brother is unharmed.

Rajaei is one of about 9,000 Iranians in Chicago stuck in a communications blackout and feeling helpless as the crack-down in Iran continues. She joined about 60 people gathered in downtown’s Congress Plaza on Saturday night at the rally organized by Chicago4Iran.

Despite the freezing cold and fears of immigration enforcement, they marched toward Federal Plaza with roses and electric candles as organizers passed out hand warmers and hugs. Many are looking West for help despite a history of failed interventions in the Middle East, and new travel restrictions from

the U.S. on Iran.

In late December, thousands of protesters in Iran took to the streets against the government of Supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and worsening economic conditions. More than 4,000 were killed, the U.S.-based Human Rights Activists News Agency said, and communications services including internet, phone and text services were shut down by authorities on Jan. 8, although some communications have been restored.

On social media, President Donald Trump expressed his

Turn to Iranians, Page 4

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Declining enrollment may lead to ‘crisis’

Report: Diminished numbers would affect system in years ahead

By Hope Moses
Chicago Tribune

Continued enrollment declines at Chicago Public Schools could escalate into a “crisis” that would significantly affect the city’s public education system in the years ahead, according to a new report from Kids First Chicago.

CPS’ current enrollment is more than 316,000 students — a near 28% decrease of more than 122,000 students since 2002-2003.

This change reflects a broader district-wide pattern driven by several factors, including a drop in birth rates over the past decade and a smaller population of school-aged children living in Chicago, according to data compiled by the local education nonprofit.

The district’s diminished student roster isn’t the crux of the problem, according to Hal Woods, chief policy officer at Kids First Chicago. “What makes this a crisis is the lack of a serious plan for how to adapt to it. That leaves students in smaller schools with fewer opportunities and no clear path forward,” he said.

His concerns underscore a crucial shift in the district over the past few years.

A decade ago, 3 out of 4 students attending school in Chicago were enrolled in CPS.

However, between 2014 and 2023, the number of school-aged children living in the city plunged by roughly 15% — or about 80,000 children — the report highlighted. Subsequently, the number of school-aged children attending CPS slid nearly 5% — or 18,000 fewer students — by 2023, the most recent data available.

And there’s more.

In 2005, the city recorded more than 45,000 live births. But by 2023, the number of live births in Chicago had dropped nearly 41%

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INSIDE



JOSE M. OSORIO/ TRIBUNE 2020

Second City changes e.t.c. Stage to improv

For the first time in its 43-year history, Chicago’s Second City e.t.c. State is changing over its stories revue to an all-improv show. **A+E**

FRIGID TEMPERATURES: Arctic blast brings warnings, closures and cancellations to the Chicago area. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Smith defends his investigations into Trump

GOP lawmakers try to thwart ex-special counsel at hearing

By Eric Tucker,
Mary Clare Jalonick,
Lisa Mascaro and
Alanna Durkin Richer
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Former Justice Department special counsel Jack Smith on Thursday defended his investigations of President Donald Trump at a public congressional hearing in which he insisted that he had acted without regard to politics and had no second thoughts about the criminal charges he

brought.

“No one should be above the law in our country, and the law required that he be held to account. So that is what I did,” Smith said of Trump.

Smith had testified behind closed doors last month but returned to the House Judiciary Committee for a public hearing Thursday that provided the prosecutor with a forum to address Congress and the country more generally about the breadth of evidence he collected during investigations that shadowed Trump during the 2024 presidential campaign and resulted in indictments.

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Former special counsel Jack Smith testifies Thursday before the House Judiciary Committee. **MARK SCHIEFELBEIN/AP**